

Euripides
Herakleidae
[The Children of Herakles]

Translated by Ian Johnston
Vancouver Island University
Nanaimo, BC.

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Introductory Note

In numbering the lines in the following English text, the translator has normally included a short indented line with the short line immediately above it, so that two or three partial lines count as a single line in the reckoning. The line numbers in square brackets refer to the Greek text; line numbers without brackets refer to the English text.

Herakleidae was first performed in Athens in 430 BC.

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HERAKLEIDAE

Dramatis Personae

IOLAUS: a friend of Herakles, an old man.
COPREUS: a herald for Eurystheus.
DEMOPHON: king of Athens, a son of Theseus.
MAKARIA: daughter of Herakles.
SERVANT: a slave of Hyllus (a son of Herakles).
ALCMENE: mother of Herakles.
MESSENGER: a slave of Alcmene.
EURYSTHEUS: king of Argos.
CHORUS: elderly citizens of Athens.
ACAMAS: brother of Demophon.
ATTENDANTS, SOLDIERS, SERVANTS.

[In front of an altar and temple of Zeus at Marathon. Iolaus and the young sons of Herakles are sitting on the steps of the altar.]

IOLAUS

Long ago I came to this conclusion—
a virtuous man is, by his nature,
someone who helps his fellow citizens,
even though he fall into misfortune,
whereas the man whose heart is wholly set
on profit is useless to his city
and difficult for his associates,
though to himself he is the best of friends.
I learned the truth of this not by hearsay,
but from experience. I could have lived 10
a quiet life in Argos, but from self-respect
and a reverence for blood kinship ties,
I worked hard—more than any other man—
to help Herakles complete his labours,
while he was still with us.¹ But now he lives
in heaven, so I protect his children,
keeping them all safe, here beneath my wings, [10]
though I myself need to be protected.²
For when their father passed on from the earth,
first, king Eurystheus wished to kill us. 20
But we ran away. We left our city,
but we saved our lives and became exiles,
wanderers driven off from one town
to another. For king Eurystheus,
in addition to the other troubles
he had given us, thought it appropriate
to abuse us. Whenever he found out
the land where we were going to settle,
he would send out his heralds, demanding [20]

¹The term “labours of Herakles” usually refers to a set of twelve very difficult tasks given to Herakles by Eurystheus, king of Argos.

²Because of his divine heritage (as a son of Zeus) and his many exploits, Herakles was granted the very rare reward of being admitted, after death, to the company of the gods on Mount Olympus.

we be surrendered or forbidden entry 30
 to that country and pointing out to them
 that it was no trivial matter to make
 the city of Argos one's friend or foe.
 He also stressed to them that he himself
 was very prosperous. These people saw
 that I had little strength, that the children
 were still small and did not have a father,
 so they bowed their heads to the stronger side
 and prevented us from entering their land.
 These children are exiles, and so am I. 40
 I share their adversities with my own.
 I am reluctant to abandon them,
 in case someone should say, "Look at that.
 Those young children do not have a father,
 and Iolaus is not protecting them, [30]
 although he is their kinsman!" That is why,
 after being shut out from everywhere
 in Greece, we have come to Marathon
 and its neighbouring land as suppliants,
 sitting here, at the altars of the gods, 50
 praying for assistance. For people say
 two sons of Theseus live in this land,
 somewhere on these plains, a territory
 they acquired thanks to a lottery held
 among the descendants of king Pandion.³
 They are both related to these children,
 and that is why we have made this journey
 to the borderlands of glorious Athens.
 Our flight is organized by two old guides—
 I worry about these boys, while Alcmene, 60 [40]
 Herakles's mother, guards his daughters,
 holding them in her arms within the shrine.
 We feel too much shame to allow young girls
 to come near the crowd or to stand outside
 as suppliants at the altar. Hyllus
 and his older brothers are searching for
 some place on earth where we can live
 in safety, in case we are pushed away,
 against our will, and have to leave this land.

[Iolaus sees the herald Copreus approaching.]

O children, children, come here. Grab my clothes. 70
 I see that herald from Eurystheus
 coming for us. He's been following us [50]
 and getting us banished as wanderers
 from everywhere on earth.

³Theseus had been king of Athens and a comrade of Herakles. The "descendants of king Pandion" are the Athenians.

[Enter Copreus.]

A curse on you,
you despicable man, and on the one
who sent you for the many evil things
that same mouth of yours has reported
about these young children's noble father!

COPREUS⁴

No doubt you think that sitting here like this
is a good refuge and that you have reached
a city that will help you. What a fool
you are to think so! For there is no one
who will prefer your feeble influence
to the power of Eurystheus. Get out!
Why go to all this trouble? You must
stand up and go to Argos, where justice
is waiting for you—a death by stoning.

80

[60]

IOLAUS

No. For the god's altar will protect me,
and the country where we stand is free.

COPREUS

Do you wish to give my hands more work to do?

90

IOLAUS

Surely you will not use force to haul
these children and myself away from here?

COPREUS

You'll see. As a prophet in this matter,
you are no expert.

IOLAUS

That will not happen,
not as long as I'm alive!

COPREUS

Out of my way!

[Iolaus and Copreus tussle, and Copreus throws Iolaus down.]

Whether you agree or not, I will take
these boys—I claim they are the property
of Eurystheus, as, in fact, they are.

⁴The Greek text uses the term Herald to indicate Copreus's speeches. I have changed that and used his name instead.

HERAKLEIDAE

IOLAUS [*shouting*]

O you citizens
who have lived a long time here in Athens,
help us! We are suppliants at the altar
of Zeus Agoraios and are being
violently attacked.⁵ Our suppliant wreaths
have been defiled—bringing shame to Athens
and dishonouring the gods!

100 [70]

[*Enter the CHORUS of elderly Athenian citizens.*]

CHORUS⁶

Hold on!
That shout coming from beside the altar—
what was it? Are we about to witness
some kind of disturbance? Look at that—
a weak old man lying there on the ground
You poor fellow, who threw you in the dirt
and made you suffer such a wretched fall?

110

IOLAUS [*pointing to Copeus*]

This man here, strangers—he insults your gods
and drags me away from Zeus's altar,
against my will.

CHORUS

But you, old man,
what place have you come from to reach this land
of four federated towns?⁷ Have you left
Euboea's shores and with your sea oars
crossed the waters and put in here?

[80]

IOLAUS

Strangers,
I do not live an island life. We have come
to your country from Mycenae.

CHORUS

What do people in Mycenae call you?

120

IOLAUS

Perhaps you have heard of Iolaus,
a man who was Herakles's comrade.
He was not unknown to fame.

⁵Agoraios meaning "of the market place" is an epithet sometimes given to Zeus.

⁶Speeches assigned to the Chorus may be spoken by the entire Chorus, part of the Chorus, or by a Chorus Leader, and a particular speech may be broken up into sections, each spoken by different members of the Chorus, as a director of a production of the play will determine.

⁷The "four federated towns" were Marathon, Oenoe, Probalinthus, and Tricorythus, all in Attica, the area around Athens (D. Kovacs).

HERAKLEIDAE

CHORUS

I learned of him
some years ago. Tell us who these young boys
you are leading by the hand belong to.

IOLAUS

Strangers, these boys are sons of Herakles.
They come as suppliants to your city.

CHORUS

What do you want? Are you interested
in talking to the city? Tell me.

IOLAUS

We do not want to be handed over
or hauled off against the will of the gods
and end up in Argos. 130

COPREUS

That will not satisfy
your masters. They own you and have found you
here in Attica. [100]

CHORUS

Stranger, it is right
to honour these suppliants to the gods.
No one should use force to make them leave
their sanctuary. For such violence
would leave sacred Justice unsatisfied.

COPREUS

Then send this property of Eurystheus
out of Attica right now. In that case,
my hands will use no force. 140

CHORUS

It is unholy
to neglect the prayers of suppliant strangers.

COPREUS

But it is good to stay out of trouble
and to come up with a more useful plan. [110]

CHORUS

Should you not have told the king of Attica
before attempting something so reckless,
rather than just dragging these strangers off
from Zeus's sanctuary against their will?
You need to respect this country's freedom.

HERAKLEIDAE

COPREUS

Who is the ruler of this land and city?

150

CHORUS

Demophon, who is nobly born, the son
of Theseus.

COPREUS

So he is the one
I really need to see to plead my case.
Those other things I said have been futile.

CHORUS

Look, here he comes in person—in a hurry—
with Acamas, his brother, to listen
to what you have to say.

[Enter Demophon and Acamas and attendants.]

DEMOPHON *[to Chorus Leader]*

You are an old man,
yet you were quicker than the younger men
in coming to Zeus's altar to help out.
So tell me, why has this crowd gathered here?
What happened?

[120]

160

CHORUS

These children are suppliants,
sitting with their wreaths laid on the altar,
as you can see, my lord. They are the sons
of Herakles. With them is Iolaus,
a trusted comrade of their father.

DEMOPHON

What happened to cause the cries for help?

CHORUS

This man tried to drag them from the altar
against their will. They started shouting out,
and the old man was knocked down in the dirt.
He looked so pitiful I shed a tear.

170

DEMOPHON

The cut of this man's clothing and the style
are Greek, but his actions are barbaric.

[130]

[Demophon turns to address Copreus.]

It is now up to you to inform me,
without wasting my time, where you come from.
What country did you leave to get here?

COPREUS

I am from Argos. That is my answer
 to what you wish to know. But I would like
 to tell you why I have come and who it was
 that sent me. I was dispatched to Attica
 by king Eurystheus of Mycenae, 180
 to apprehend these children. I have come,
 stranger, with many lawful rights to justify
 what I say and do. I am an Argive,
 and I am taking back these Argives,
 who have absconded from my native land. [140]
 Our country's laws have sentenced them to death,
 and the inhabitants of any city state
 have the power, on their own, to enforce
 stringent sentences on their own citizens.
 We have visited the homes of many others 190
 and have appealed to these same principles.
 No one has yet dared to make more trouble
 for himself. But these Argives have come here
 because they see some weaknesses in you,
 or, not knowing what to do, are risking
 a roll of the dice to ascertain whether
 you are or are not a naïve, witless fool.
 For surely they do not assume that you, [150]
 if you are thinking clearly, will somehow
 be the only one of all Hellenic states 200
 they have approached to sympathize with them
 and their foolish troubles. Come then, weigh
 both arguments—you can either allow
 these people into your state, or let us
 apprehend them. Which of these two options
 brings you the greater benefit? From us
 you will gain the following—your city
 will be allied to Argos and its army
 and to all of Eurystheus's power.
 But if you listen to their proposals 210
 and their lamentations and grow soft,
 that will bring this matter to a contest
 with our spears. For you should not assume [160]
 that we will abandon this argument
 without a clash of steel. What will you say
 is your pretext for going to war? Have you
 been robbed of any land? What has been stolen
 that has made you launch a war with Argos?
 What allies are you defending? Those men
 who perish—for whose sake were they buried? 220
 Your citizens will have harsh things to say
 against you, if, for the sake of one old man,
 a walking corpse who, as the saying goes,
 is only half alive, and for these children,

you step into a quagmire. The best thing
 you can say is that at present these children
 offer hope, nothing more, and this hope
 will not do very much to satisfy [170]
 your present needs. Even when fully grown,
 these boys would not do well in any war 230
 against the armed might of the Argives—
 if that is something that excites your heart—
 and the time between then and now is long,
 during which you could be utterly destroyed.
 Take my advice. Do not give me anything,
 but permit me to take with me what is mine,
 and you will gain Mycenae as an ally.
 Do not do what you Athenians love to do,
 make the weaker side your friends at a time
 you could have chosen much stronger allies. 240

CHORUS

Who can decide a case or judge a plea
 without clearly hearing from both sides? [180]

IOLAUS

My lord, in your land it is well established
 that I have a right to hear and speak in turn,
 without being pushed away by anyone
 before I finish, as people do elsewhere.

[Iolaus turns to indicate Copreus.]

We have nothing in common with this man.
 For since the vote was passed, we no longer
 have anything at all to do with Argos—
 we are exiles from our native land. 250
 How is it right that this man leads us off
 as Mycenaean, when they have banished us
 from Mycenae? For we are foreigners.
 Or do you think it right that anyone [190]
 exiled from Argos should be banished
 from all of Greece? Surely not from Athens.
 They will not drive Herakles's children
 out of their land because they fear the Argives.
 This is not Trachis or an Achaean town,
 from which you had these children banished, 260
 though they were suppliants at the altars.
 You cited no legal right but boasted
 about Argos, just as you have done today
 in what you said. If that happens again,
 and these people declare your argument
 the winner, I will not think that Athens
 is a free country any more. But still,
 I know the nature and spirit of these people.

They are willing to die, for in good men [200]
 honour is more valuable than life itself. 270
 Enough about the city—too much praise
 can be invidious. I myself acknowledge
 I have often been annoyed by praise
 that is excessive.

[Iolaus turns his attention to Demophon.]

But I wish to tell you
 it is your duty, as ruler of this land,
 to save these children. For Pittheus
 was the son of Pelops, and he fathered
 Aethra, who was mother of Theseus,
 your father. Now I will trace the ancestry
 of these children. Herakles was the son 280 [210]
 of Zeus and Alcmene, who was a child
 of Pelops. Thus, their father and your father
 were the sons of cousins. And that is how,
 Demophon, you are related to these boys.
 But I will tell you of an obligation,
 apart from kinship, you have to these lads.
 I maintain that years ago, while I was
 Herakles's shield bearer, I sailed off
 with Theseus to fetch that murderous belt
 belonging to Hippolyta. As reward 290
 Herakles gave Theseus fair Antiope.
 After that Herakles brought your father
 back from the dark fortresses of Hades.
 All Greece bears witness to this story.
 Because of this, his children now request [220]
 repayment from you—not to be surrendered
 or dragged away by force from the altars
 of your gods or banished from your country.
 For it reflects a special shame on you
 and trouble for the city, if suppliants, 300
 wanderers, and kinsmen are hauled away
 against their will. Alas for all the suffering,
 Look at them, just look!

[Iolaus kneels down in front of Demophon.]

I entreat you,
 placing my suppliant wreath in your arms
 and touching your beard, do not dishonour
 the sons of Herakles. They are in your hands.
 Be their kinsman, friend, father, brother, master, [230]
 for anything is better than falling
 into Argive hands.

CHORUS

My lord, I have heard
 about their troubles, and I pity them. 310
 Their noble birth has been overpowered
 by misfortune. I understand that now,
 more so than ever. For these young children,
 born from a noble father, are victims
 of circumstances they do not deserve.

DEMOPHON

There are three main concerns, Iolaus,
 that compel me not to dismiss your words.
 The most important is Zeus. You are sitting
 at his altar with this group of fledglings.
 Second, kinship ties and the ancient debt 320 [240]
 that I should treat these children very well
 for their father's sake. And last, my honour,
 the issue that must be my main concern.
 For if I permit a foreign stranger
 to violate this altar, people will think
 that the land I live in is no longer free
 and that I surrendered the suppliants
 because I feared the Argives—and that thought
 almost makes me want to hang myself.
 I wish that you had come with better luck, 330
 but even so, do not fear that anyone
 will forcibly remove you and the children
 from this altar.

[Demophon turns his attention to Copreus.]

As for you, go to Argos. [250]
 Report what happened here to Eurystheus.
 Tell him, in addition, that if he wishes
 to level charges against these strangers,
 he will be treated justly. But never
 will you take these children.

COPREUS

Not even
 if I have a lawful case and win
 the verbal arguments?

DEMOPHON

How is it just 340
 to forcibly kidnap a suppliant?

COPREUS

Surely that would bring disgrace to me
 but do no harm to you?

HERAKLEIDAE

DEMOPHON

The shame is mine,
if I allow you to take these children.

COPREUS

Just banish them. Then leave the rest to us.

DEMOPHON

You are foolish to think you know better
than the gods.

COPREUS

It seems Athens is a place
where evildoers will find a refuge.

DEMOPHON

A god's sanctuary is a defence
all people share in common.

[260]

350

COPREUS

Those in Mycenae may not think the same.

DEMOPHON

Am I not in control of matters here?

COPREUS

Yes, if you are wise and do not harm them.

DEMOPHON

Let them be harmed! I will not offend the gods.

COPREUS

I would prefer it if you did not wage war
with Argos.

DEMOPHON

So would I. But these suppliants
will not be handed over.

COPREUS

Then I will seize them
and lead them off, for they belong to me.

DEMOPHON

Your trip back to Argos may not be easy.

COPREUS

I could make the attempt, and then I'll see.

360

HERAKLEIDAE

DEMOPHON

If you touch them, you will have good reason
an instant later to regret it. [270]

CHORUS

By the gods,
you must not dare to strike a herald!

DEMOPHON

I will, unless he learns some common sense.

CHORUS [*to Copreus*]

You should go.

[*Turning to Demophon*]

And you, my lord, should not touch him.

COPREUS

I am going. To fight with just one arm
is feeble, but I will come back here
with a great many Argive infantry,
all bronze-clad spearmen. Thousands of men
are expecting me, all warriors, 370
led by Eurystheus, their commander,
on the borders of Alcathous's realm,
waiting to see how these events turn out
in Attica. When he learns of my report [280]
about your insolence, he will be here
in all his fury for you, your citizens,
your property, and your harvest crops.
It would be senseless for Argos to possess
a large army of young men in their prime
if we did not punish you.

[*Exit Copreus and his attendants.*]

DEMOPHON

Get out of here! 380
Your Argos does not inspire fear in me,
and you will not be leading suppliants
from here by force and putting me to shame.
For the city I control is independent
and not subject to the rule of Argos.

CHORUS

Time now for us to prepare ourselves,
before the Argive army marches near
the borders of our land. The spirit of war
in the Mycenaeans is very sharp, [290]
especially now, after what happened here. 390

For heralds like to exaggerate reports—
 it's a habit they all share—they inflate
 a story until it is twice as large
 as what really happened. How big a tale
 do you think he is reporting to the king—
 how he suffered terrible mistreatment
 and only just escaped here with his life?

IOLAUS

Being born from a good and noble father
 is the finest honour for his children
 and marrying into a noble family. 400

I will not praise a man conquered by lust
 who, for the sake of his own pleasure,
 associates with low-born women and leaves [300]
 his children an inheritance of shame.

Noble birth protects against misfortune
 better than base parentage. We have found,
 after falling into the deepest misery,
 friends and relatives here, the only men
 in all of Greece who will defend these boys.
 Come children, give these men your right hands, 410
 and you men, give the children yours. Come closer.

[The Chorus and the children shake hands.]

Children, we have just experienced
 what it means to have good friends. So if ever
 you go back home one day and occupy [310]
 your ancestral home and regain once more
 your father's honours, you must always think
 of those who rule Athens as your saviours
 and your friends. Remember this, and never
 raise a hostile army against this land.

Consider Athens your greatest friend of all. 420
 Its citizens deserve your reverence,
 for they have helped us out and in exchange
 they have earned the enmity of Argos,
 a great land with a powerful army.

Even though they could easily perceive
 that we were poor wanderers and beggars,
 they did not hand us over or drive us
 from their land. While I am still alive,
 I shall not stop proclaiming your nobility [320]
 to everyone and once I have passed on—
 whenever that may be—I will be standing
 close to Theseus and singing your praise. 430

I will delight his heart by telling him
 how kind you were to welcome and protect
 Herakles's children, and how nobly
 you preserve your father's reputation

HERAKLEIDAE

throughout Greece, and how, though nobly born,
you are no less worthy than your father.
Of few others can one say that one man
out of a great many may perhaps be found 440
who is not inferior to his father.

CHORUS

This land has always sought to help the weak
when their cause is just. That is the reason [330]
Athens has undertaken countless tasks
to help out her friends. And now I see
we have another struggle on our hands.

DEMOPHON

You have spoken well, old man. I am sure
these boys will act just as you suggested—
they will not forget our kindness to them.
I will call the citizens together 450
and organize them, so that we can meet
the Mycenaean army with a large force.
First I will sent out scouts to spy on them,
so they do not attack me unawares.
For in Argos every man is very quick
to answer the call. Then I will summon
the prophets and prepare a sacrifice. [340]
You should leave Zeus's altar, old man,
and go to the palace with the children.
There are people there who will care for you, 460
even if I am absent. So go there.

IOLAUS

I will not leave the altar. We suppliants
will remain here and pray that the city
is successful. When Athens has emerged
victorious from the struggle, we will move
into the palace. The gods we have as allies
are no worse than those the Argives have,
my lord. For their champion is Hera,
Zeus's wife. Our chief god is Athena,
and I say that is fortunate for us— 470 [350]
we have the stronger god—for Pallas
will never accept suffering a defeat.

[Exit Demophon and his attendants.]

CHORUS

O stranger from Argos, you may have uttered
an impressive boast, but that does not make
men think of you as greater than you are.
Your grand talk does not make my heart afraid.

HERAKLEIDAE

I pray that it will be many a year
before that happens to mighty Athens,
a city with such lovely dancing grounds!
But you are foolish, as is Eurystheus, 480 [360]
son of Sthenelus, your Argive tyrant.

You have now come to another city,
no less a power than Argos, and tried,
though you are a foreigner, to drag away
by force these suppliants to the gods,
these wanderers begging my land for help,
without deferring to our king or making
any plea for justice. How can such things
be considered fair by those who reason well? [370]

As for me, I love peace. But I tell you, 490
you malicious king, if you march to Athens,
you will not get what you expect to gain.
You are not the only one with a spear
and a shield of bronze. No, you may love war,
but do not disturb our graceful city
with your sword. Hold yourself in check. [380]

[Enter Demophon with attendants.]

IOLAUS

My son, why have you returned to us
with such a look of worry in your eyes?
Are you going to speak of something new
about the enemy? Are they delaying? 500
Are they already here? What have you heard?
Surely you will not contradict those words
the herald uttered. For their commander,
who has enjoyed success before, will march
to Athens—I am sure of that. His ambitions
are not small. But as you are well aware,
Zeus punishes ideas that are too proud.

DEMOPHON

The army of the Argives has arrived,
led by Eurystheus. I have seen him [390]
with my own eyes, for anyone who claims
to possess a thorough understanding 510
of what it means to be a general
should not observe an enemy's forces
merely by means of messengers. So far
he has not yet brought his forces down
into the plains of Attica. Instead,
he is encamped on a rock-covered ridge,
weighing his options (I am telling you
what I think is going on), figuring out

the route to take to bring his great army 520
 safely down to the borders of our lands
 and then to set up camp. My own plans
 have already been carefully prepared—
 the city is armed, sacrificial beasts
 stand ready to be slaughtered to the gods [400]
 to whom such gifts are due, and in the city
 prophets are dedicating offerings.
 After assembling together in one place
 all those who chant the oracles, I looked
 very closely at what they had been saying 530
 in public and in old secret prophecies
 dealing with the safety of the city.
 These utterances were very different
 in what they said about many matters,
 but on one issue they were all the same—
 they told me that if I wanted to defeat
 the enemy forces and save the city
 I should sacrifice to Demeter's daughter
 a young girl born to a noble father.⁸
 Now, as you can see, I am very eager 540 [410]
 to assist you. But I will not slaughter
 my own daughter, and I will not compel
 any of my citizens to do so,
 against their will. Who is so misguided
 that he would quite willingly hand over
 the child he loves more than any other?
 Now you may be seeing crowded meetings
 where some people argue that it was right
 to help out strangers who are suppliants,
 while others denounce me for my folly. 550
 If I do what the oracles demand,
 we will immediately have civil war.
 You should bear all this in mind and help me [420]
 find a way to save you and this land, as well,
 without making the citizens resent me.
 I am not like some barbarian tyrant—
 the citizens will deal justly with me
 only if what I do for them is just.

CHORUS

But is a god really telling our city
 not to assist strangers who need our help, 560
 when Athens is eager to protect them?

IOLAUS

My children, we are just like seafarers
 who have escaped the fierce rage of a storm
 and have dry land almost within their grasp,

⁸Demeter's daughter is Persephone, a goddess married to Hades, god of the underworld and the dead.

then are driven by winds away from shore [430]
 out into the sea again. That is how
 we are being driven away from land
 when we had already reached the coast
 and were feeling safe. Alas! Cruel hope,
 why then did you offer me so much joy 570
 if you did not mean to complete the gift?
 I can understand Demophon's position—
 he does not wish to sacrifice the children
 of his citizens. I am even thankful
 for the way we have been treated here.
 If the gods wish me to end up like this,
 my gratitude to you remains the same.
 I do not know what I can do for you,
 my children. Where can we turn? What god [440]
 have we not petitioned with our garlands? 580
 In what land have we not sought protection?
 We will be handed over, my children.
 We will be killed. I do not really care
 that I must die, except that by dying
 I might give pleasure to my enemies.
 But I weep for you, children. I pity you—
 and old Alcmene, your father's mother.
 How wretched she must feel to live so long!
 How miserable I am to have worked
 so many years in vain. It is our fate. 590
 Yes, our fate—to fall into enemy hands
 and lose our lives in misery and shame. [450]

[Iolaus turns his attention to Demophon.]

But I have not lost all hope of rescuing
 the children—and I know you will assist me.
 Hand me over to the Argives, my lord,
 rather than these children. Do not place yourself
 in danger, but save the children for me.
 I do not need to cling to life—let it go.
 Eurystheus would be especially pleased
 to capture me and mock an old ally 600
 of Herakles. He is a stupid man.
 Wise men should pray they have an enemy
 known for his wisdom, not someone proud
 and senseless—with the former one may get
 a full measure of respect and justice. [460]

CHORUS

Old friend, do not blame the city for this.
 Although it would be telling lies about us,
 to say we have betrayed these strangers
 is a harsh rebuke.

DEMOPHON [*to Iolaus*]

What you have proposed
 is noble, but it is not feasible. 610
 The king has not come here with an army
 because he wants you. For what benefit
 is there for Eurystheus in the death
 of an old man? No, he wishes to kill
 the children. The offspring of noble men
 are terrifying to their enemies
 when they grow up and still remember
 how their father was abused. Eurystheus
 has to take all of this into account. [470]
 Still, if you can come up with a plan, 620
 something more suitable than the last one,
 let me know. For I have heard the oracles—
 they fill me with fear, and I feel helpless.

[*Enter Makaria, Herakles's daughter, from inside the temple.*]MAKARIA⁹

Strangers, please do not think I am too bold
 in coming out here. That is my first request.
 For a woman, it is best to stay silent
 and act prudently, remaining quiet
 inside the house. But when I heard you groan,
 Iolaus, I came outside. The family
 has not designated me their spokesman, 630
 but in some ways I am fit to be that, [480]
 because I truly care about my brothers
 and myself, and I would like to ask you
 if, in addition to all our ancient grief,
 some new trouble is gnawing at your heart.

IOLAUS

My child, for some time now I have praised you
 as the very best of Herakles's children.
 It seemed to us that that things were going well,
 but now they have changed back once again
 and we are beyond all help. The king declares 640
 that those who chant the oracles have said
 if we and the city are to survive
 we must make a sacrificial offering
 to Demeter's daughter, not with a bull
 or calf, but with a nobly born young girl. [490]
 But this we cannot do. The king asserts
 he will not sacrifice his own children
 or those of anyone else. And he tells me—
 not explicitly, but with subtle hints—

⁹The Greek text uses the word for young girl (*parthenos*) to designate Herakles's daughter. I have substituted her name throughout.

that, if we cannot resolve this problem, 650
 we must find some other land to go to,
 for he desires to keep this country safe.

MAKARIA

That prophecy is threatening our safety?

IOLAUS

Yes, the prophecy. In everything else
 our fortunes are fine.

MAKARIA

Then you no longer [500]
 need to fear the enemy's Argive spear.
 For I am prepared, old man, quite freely
 and before some man gives me an order,
 to offer myself up for sacrifice
 and to be killed. For what will we say 660
 if this city considers it worthwhile
 to run great risks on our behalf, while we
 load our own troubles onto other people
 and run from death, when we could save them?
 That is not right. It would be ridiculous
 if we sit groaning as suppliants to the gods
 and yet demonstrate that we are cowards, [510]
 though we are all children of Herakles,
 our great father. How can this be fitting
 among men of honour? It would be finer, 670
 I suppose, if this city were captured—
 may the gods prevent that from taking place!
 Then I, daughter of a noble father,
 would be dishonoured and go to my death,
 and thus the end result would be the same.
 Should I then be banished from Attica
 and become a wanderer? Would I not
 feel ashamed if someone said to me,
 "Why have you come here with suppliant boughs,
 when you are afraid to die? Leave this land. 680
 We are not prepared to help out cowards."
 But if these boys perished and I lived on, [520]
 I would have no hope of being happy.
 Before now many have sought happiness
 by betraying their friends. For who would want
 to have a girl without family as a wife
 or make me the mother of his children?
 Surely it is better to die than to endure
 this fate, which I do not deserve, a fate
 that is more appropriate for someone 690
 who is not as nobly born as I am.
 Take me to the place where I will die,
 crown me with garlands, and begin the rites,

if that is what you want, and then defeat
 the enemy. For I offer you my life [530]
 willingly and under no compulsion.
 I affirm that I am ready to die
 for my brothers' sake and for my own.
 For I have discovered a splendid fact—
 by not being too much in love with life, 700
 as cowards are, I can die with glory.

CHORUS

Ah, what shall I say after listening
 to the courageous words of this young girl,
 who is ready to die for her brothers?
 Who could utter more noble words than these?
 What mortal man could later act on them?

IOLAUS

My child, you can be no one else's daughter
 but his—born from the seed of Herakles, [540]
 from his godlike spirit. I feel so proud
 of what you have just said, although I grieve 710
 for your fate. But I will suggest a method
 that is more just for deciding what to do.
 We have to summon all your sisters here,
 and the one who draws the lot must die
 to save the family. It is not right
 for you to die without a lottery.

MAKARIA

I will not die by some chance lottery!
 For in that, old man, there is no glory.
 Do not suggest it. Instead, if you approve
 of me and wish to act as I propose, 720 [550]
 I am prepared to die for my brothers—
 but not if I am compelled to do it.

IOLAUS

Ah, this last speech of yours is more noble
 than the one before, and that was excellent!
 Your bravery and your noble language
 are more impressive every time you speak.
 I am not telling you to die, my child,
 but I am not forbidding you to do it.
 Still, your death will benefit your brothers.

MAKARIA

You are wise to absolve yourself of guilt. 730
 You need not fear that you will share the stain
 of murder. I go to my death quite freely.
 But follow me, old friend, for I would like [560]
 to perish in your arms. Stand beside me,

and cover my dead body with my robe.
 Follow me, for I am now on my way
 to the terrors of a bloody sacrifice,
 if I am truly born from that great man
 who I claim is my father.

IOLAUS

To stand by
 as you meet your death—I cannot do that!

740

MAKARIA

Well then, can you ask this man if I might
 draw my last breath in the hands of women,
 rather than of men.

DEMOPHON

Your wish is granted,
 you poor, suffering girl. I would be shamed
 if you were not treated with great honour.
 There are many reasons—your bravery
 and the justice of what you are asking.
 You are the most courageous of all women,
 the bravest these eyes of mine have ever seen.
 Now, if you wish, you should say your last words
 to your brothers and the old man. Then go.

[570]

750

MAKARIA

Farewell, old man, farewell. Please teach these boys,
 for my sake, to be men just like yourself,
 wise in all things—no need for more than that,
 which will be quite enough. With all your heart
 strive to save them from death. We are your babes,
 raised by your hands. You see me sacrifice
 my married life and going to my death
 for their sakes. And you, my brothers, gathered
 here with me, may you have a happy life
 and experience all those things my heart
 will never know. Treat with all due respect
 this old man and the old woman in the house,
 Alcmene, my grandmother, and these men,
 your hosts. And if the gods ever grant you
 a release from trouble and a journey home,
 remember what kind of burial rights
 you ought to give the young girl who saved you.
 I think they should be the very finest,
 for I did not fail to stand up for you
 but went to my death for the family.
 These things I have as valuable treasures
 instead of children and my virgin life,
 if, in fact, we exist beneath the earth.
 I hope we do not, for if we mortals

[580]

760

770

[590]

about to die have to deal with troubles
 even in that place, then I do not know
 where anyone can turn. For people claim
 that death is the greatest cure for pain.

IOLAUS

O you most courageous of all women, 780
 know this—in life and in death we hold you
 in the very greatest honour! Farewell.
 I dare not speak ill of the deity [600]
 to whom your body is being sacrificed—
 the daughter of the goddess Demeter.

[Demophon escorts Makaria away.]

My children,
 I am done for. My limbs are giving way
 from grief. Take me and set me down right here,
 on a seat beside the altar. Use my clothes
 to conceal my head. What has happened
 brings me no joy, yet if the oracle 790
 is not fulfilled, I could not go on living,
 for my ruin would be even greater.
 What we have now is a catastrophe.

[Iolaus is helped to a seat, he lies down, and his head is covered.]

CHORUS

I say no man is blessed or cursed by fate
 except by the will of the gods. The same house
 does not always follow good fortune's path. [610]
 One fate after another hunts us down—
 it takes a man from his eminent rank
 and reduces him to insignificance.
 It makes a vagabond a wealthy man. 800
 No one can flee from fate or use his wisdom
 to set it aside, and any man who tries
 will always face a host of futile struggles.

But do not prostrate yourself and lament
 what the gods have given, or spend your time
 in constant grieving, heart full of pain. [620]
 For the poor girl has won a glorious death,
 dying for this land and her brothers too,
 and men will welcome her glorious fame.
 True virtue walks through paths of hardship. 810
 What she is doing is worthy of her father,
 and worthy of her noble family.
 If you honour the virtuous dead,
 then I will share in honouring them, too.

[Enter a servant of Hyllus.]

SERVANT

Greetings, children! Old man Iolaus
and your grandmother have left the altar.
Where have they gone?

[630]

IOLAUS

I am over here,
if my presence means anything at all.

SERVANT

Why are you lying there? Why the sad face?

IOLAUS

A pressing family matter—I was preoccupied.

820

SERVANT

It is time to rouse yourself. Lift your head.

IOLAUS

I am an old man. I do not have the strength.

SERVANT

But I have come bringing you joyful news.

IOLAUS

Who are you? Where have I met you? I forget.

SERVANT

I am a slave belonging to Hyllus.
Do you not recognize me?

IOLAUS

My dear man,
you got here safely then?

[640]

SERVANT

Yes I did.
Not only that but at the moment
your fortunes are looking good.

IOLAUS *[shouting into the temple]*

Alcmene,
you mother of a noble son, come out here
and listen to the encouraging words
of this man here. You have been anxious,
heart sick with worry, for a long time now,
wondering if those who have just arrived
would ever make it back.

830

HERAKLEIDAE

[Enter Alcmene from the temple.]

ALCMENE

Iolaus,
why this shouting through the entire shrine?
Has another herald come from Argos
to force us out? My body may be frail,
stranger, but you should consider this—
you will never take away these children
while I am still alive, or else let me
no longer be called Herakles's mother.
If you lay a hand on them, you will face
a bitter struggle with two ancient foes.

840 [650]

IOLAUS

Be brave, old woman. Do not be afraid.
No herald has come from Argos bringing
a threatening message.

ALCMENE

Then why did you shout
and make me think you were afraid?

IOLAUS

To make you come out of the temple
and meet this man.

ALCMENE

I do not understand.
Who is he?

850

IOLAUS

A messenger with news—
your grandson has returned.

ALCMENE

Greetings to you,
and may you find joy for bringing us this news!
If he has set foot in Attica, then why
has he not returned to us? Where is he?
What misfortune stops him from coming here
with you and bringing joy into my heart?

[660]

SERVANT

He is setting up camp and marshalling troops
for the army he brought here with him.

ALCMENE

That news
about his army is no concern of mine.

860

HERAKLEIDAE

IOLAUS

Yes, it is. And my business is to ask about it.

SERVANT

What do you want to know about the army?

IOLAUS

How many allies does he have with him?

SERVANT

A great many. I cannot provide you
a more detailed number.

IOLAUS

I assume [670]
the leaders of the Athenians know this.

SERVANT

They do. What's more, they have placed his army
on our left wing.

IOLAUS

What? Is our army
already prepared for battle?

SERVANT

It is—
they have brought the sacrificial offerings
into the ranks. 870

IOLAUS

And the Argive forces—
how far away are they?

SERVANT

They are close enough.
One can clearly make out their commander.

IOLAUS

What is he doing? Drawing up the enemy lines?

SERVANT

We think so. But we could not hear his voice.
But I must go. I do not want my master
to charge the enemy without me there
doing my part.

IOLAUS

I will go with you. [680]
It seems we both are having the same idea—
we should be with our friends and help them out. 880

HERAKLEIDAE

SERVANT

It is not at all like you to speak such nonsense.

IOLAUS

It is not like me not to assist my friends
in battle.

SERVANT

The strength you used to have,
my friend, has long since left you.

IOLAUS

Well, in any case,
I can fight as many warriors as before.

SERVANT

What you add to your friends' force is minuscule.

[690]

IOLAUS

None of the enemy will dare confront me.

SERVANT

The sight of you will not harm anyone,
unless your hand and arm can do their work.

IOLAUS

What? Could not a blow from me smash their shields?

890

SERVANT

You might strike a blow, but before that happens,
you could collapse.

IOLAUS

Do not try to stop me
when I am prepared and ready to fight.

SERVANT

You may perhaps be eager to take part,
but you lack the strength.

IOLAUS

I am not staying here
no matter what you say.

SERVANT

You have no weapons.
How are you going to play the warrior?

IOLAUS

Inside the temple there are captured weapons.

I will use them. If I am still alive,
 I will give them back, but if I die, 900
 the god will not ask me to return them.
 Go inside, and take a set of armour
 from its peg. Then bring it here to me
 as quickly as you can. Staying at home,
 while some men join in the fighting [700]
 and the cowards hang back, is disgraceful.

[The Servant exits into the temple.]

CHORUS

Time has not yet dimmed your spirit—
 it is still young, although your physical strength
 has disappeared. Why do you toil so hard 910
 in vain struggles that might well injure you
 and bring no benefits to our city?
 At your age you should curb your urge to fight
 and forget about what is impossible—
 you will never live your youthful years again.

ALCMENE

What are you doing? Have you lost your mind? [710]
 Are you intending to abandon me
 with my grandchildren?

IOLAUS

Fighting is men's concern.
 You need to take care of the children.

ALCMENE

But if you are killed, how will I survive?

IOLAUS

Your son's children will look after all those 920
 who are left behind.

ALCMENE

But what if—heaven forbid!—
 something bad happens to them?

IOLAUS

Do not be afraid.
 Our hosts here will not hand you over.

ALCMENE

That is my only hope. There is nothing else.

IOLAUS

And Zeus, I know, cares for your suffering.

HERAKLEIDAE

ALCMENE

Ah yes, Zeus. He will not hear me saying
bad things about him. But he himself knows
whether he has treated me with justice.

[Enter Servant from the temple, carrying armour.]

SERVANT

You see here a complete set of armour.
It is time to put it on and get going,
for the fighting is about to start,
and war god Ares truly hates all those
who dawdle. If the weight of these weapons
worries you, you can go out as you are,
without them, and when you are in the ranks
you can put on your gear. In the meantime
I will carry it.

[720]

930

IOLAUS

That is a good idea.
Keep the armour close to me and ready.
Put a spear in my hand and support me
by my left forearm, directing my steps.

940

SERVANT

Must I guide a warrior like a child?

IOLAUS

I must not stumble—it's a bad omen.

[730]

SERVANT

I wish your power to act matched your spirit.

IOLAUS

Hurry up! It will be a disaster
if I miss the fighting.

SERVANT

You are the one
who is moving slowly, not me. You think
you are marching quickly, but you are not.

IOLAUS

Can't you see how fast my legs are moving?

SERVANT

I see you think you are moving quickly,
but you are very slow.

HERAKLEIDAE

IOLAUS

When you see me there, 950
you will not be saying things like that.

SERVANT

What will you be doing? At any rate,
I wish you great success!

IOLAUS

I will be smashing
one of the enemy . . . right through his shield.

SERVANT

Perhaps . . . if we ever get there. I fear
we may not be in time.

IOLAUS

Ah, how I wish
you arms of mine, my allies in this fight, [740]
could be as strong as you were in your prime!
I still remember how with Herakles
you ransacked Sparta! If so, I could make 960
king Eurystheus turn and run! I tell you
that man is too much a coward to face
a hostile spear. And it is wrong to think
that one who has success is therefore brave,
though all of us assume a prosperous man
is fortunate in everything he does.

[Iolaus and the Servant leave.]

CHORUS

O Earth and night-linging Moon,
O dazzling radiance of the god
who sends rays of light to mortal men, [750]
carry this message for me—shout it out 970
to heaven, to the throne of Zeus,
and in grey-eyed Athena's shrine.
For we have welcomed suppliants here,
and now, for the sake of our native land,
for the sake our homes, we must slice
through danger with our gleaming steel.

It makes me fearful that a wealthy city
like Mycenae, famous for its power [760]
in war, should feel such hatred for my land.
But, my countrymen, it is disgraceful 980
if we surrender suppliant strangers
in obedience to commands from Argos.
Zeus is my ally, and I am not afraid.
Zeus justly shows goodwill to me—

HERAKLEIDAE

so I shall never assert that gods
are lesser beings than mortal men.

But, divine Athena, you possess [770]
this land and city—you are its mother,
its queen, its guardian. Turn aside
the man who is unjustly leading here 990
a spear-brandishing force from Argos.
For we are virtuous, so it is not right
that we be driven from our homes.

For we are always offering
grand sacrifices in your honour—
as the month reaches its final day,
we do not forget our youthful songs [780]
or the chanting choruses. Shouts of joy
ring out on wind-swept hills all night
to the rhythm of young girls' dancing feet. 1000

[Enter a Messenger.]

MESSENGER

My lady, I bring a very short report,
but it will sound like music to your ears—
we have overpowered the Argives!
Trophies of victory are being set up
bearing the armour of your enemies.

ALCMENE

Dear friend, this day is a happy one for you—
this message of yours gives you your freedom!
But you have not yet relieved my mind [790]
of one misfortune—for I am anxious
whether those I cherish are still alive. 1010

MESSENGER

They are alive, and throughout the army
they have won great fame.

ALCMENE

Is he still living? And old Iolaus?

SERVANT

Yes, indeed he is.
The gods have granted him the best of fortunes.

ALCMENE

What do you mean? Did he fight bravely?

MESSENGER

He has changed. The old man is young again!

ALCMENE

What you say is amazing! But first of all
I would like you to tell me that our friends
and family have prevailed in battle.

MESSENGER

I will describe the entire fight to you 1020
in a single speech. Once the warriors
had been drawn up into extended lines [800]
facing one another, Hyllus stepped down
from his four-horse chariot and stood there,
in the middle ground between the armies.
Then he cried, "Commander of the Argives,
why can we not leave this land of ours alone!
You would not make Athens your enemy,
nor would you inflict damage on Mycenae,
by killing off its soldiers. Instead of that, 1030
you and I should fight in single combat.
If you kill me, then you can take away
Herakles's children. If I kill you,
I regain the honours and the estates [810]
belonging to my father." The army
indicated its approval of the speech,
for his words were splendidly courageous
and they relieved them of the pains of war.
But Eurystheus paid no attention
to the soldiers who had heard the challenge 1040
and felt no shame at his own cowardice,
though he was commander of the army,
for he did not dare to come within range
of a hostile spear. Is this the craven fool
who came to enslave Herakles's children?
Hyllus moved back into the ranks once more.
When the priests realized that there would be [820]
no conclusion to the war brought about
by single combat, they at once began
to slaughter the sacrificial animals 1050
and let streams of auspicious blood flow out
from the gullets of the beasts. Some warriors
mounted their chariots. Others bunched up,
shoulder to shoulder, protected by their shields.
The leader of the Athenian army
urged on his troops the way a brave man should:
"Fellow citizens, now we must protect
the land that gave us birth and nurtured us."
The enemy general, Eurystheus,
entreated his allies not to disgrace 1060
Argos and Mycenae. When the shrill cry

of the Tuscan trumpet gave the signal,
 the two armies charged at one another.
 Can you imagine the tremendous din
 of clashing shields and groans and cries of pain,
 all intermingled? At first the onslaught
 of the Argive spearmen broke through our ranks,
 but they pulled back again, and then the troops
 went at it, foot against foot, man to man,
 in fiercely contested battle. Many men died. 1070
 You could hear the shouts from both the armies,
 "You Athenians," or "You who sow the fields
 in Argos, will you not protect our city [840]
 from disgrace?" We fought on with all our strength
 and, with a tremendous effort, at last
 turned the Argive line and put them to flight.
 When old Iolaus saw Hyllus moving off,
 he stretched out his right arm and begged Hyllus
 to let him mount up into his chariot.
 Then he grabbed the reins and started chasing 1080
 Eurystheus's horses. Up to this point
 what I have described I saw for myself,
 but from here on the events I mention
 I heard from others. As Iolaus
 was riding past the rock in Pallenis,
 sacred to divine Athena, chasing [850]
 the chariot of Eurystheus, he prayed
 to Hebe and to Zeus that he could be
 young again for just one day and exact
 righteous vengeance from his enemies.¹⁰ 1090
 Now you will hear something astonishing.
 Twin stars now stood above the chariot yoke
 and wrapped the chariot in a dark cloud.
 Those who are wise in such matters say
 the stars were your son Herakles and Hebe.
 Then from the murky darkness Iolaus
 appeared, a young man with strong youthful arms.
 Glorious Iolaus captured Eurystheus
 in his chariot near the cliffs of Sciron, [860]
 bound his arms with rope, and made his way back 1100
 leading that general, once so prosperous,
 now the most splendid initial prize of war.
 With this present twist of fate, Eurystheus
 announces clearly that all mortal beings
 should not envy those favoured by fortune
 until you witness how they meet their death,
 for fortune's gifts last but a single day.

CHORUS

O Zeus, who brings this victory,

¹⁰Hebe was the goddess of youth. She was also the wife of Herakles in heaven.

HERAKLEIDAE

now I see the day when I am freed
from terrible fear!

ALCMENE

O Zeus, 1110
at last you have turned a favouring eye
on my misfortunes—yet I am grateful [870]
for what you have done. Before this moment
I did not believe my son Herakles
now lived among the gods, but after this
I am convinced he does. O children,
now you will be free from suffering,
free from Eurystheus, who is going
to face a dreadful death. You will now see
your father's city and come to possess 1120
your own estates. And you will sacrifice
to the gods of your ancestors, from whom
you have been cut off, living the pitiful life
of vagrant strangers. But what clever plan
did Iolaus have in mind when he spared [880]
the life of Eurystheus? Explain that.
For in my opinion it is not prudent,
after you have captured your enemies,
not to make them pay the penalty.

MESSENGER

He was honouring you, so you might see 1130
Eurystheus with your own eyes—terrified
and entirely subject to your wishes.
He did not come willingly. Iolaus
used force to yolk him to necessity,
for Eurystheus did not wish to move
into your presence while he was alive
and meet his punishment. And now farewell,
old lady. Please remember what you said
at the start when I began my story—
you promised me I could have my freedom. 1140
In such matters what well born people say [890]
ought to be the truth.

[Exit Messenger.]

CHORUS

At a feast I love to dance and listen
to the joyful, shrill notes of a flute,
as Aphrodite spreads out her delights,
and there is joy in witnessing our friends
become successful, when earlier
no one thought they would amount to much.
For Life, Time's child, engenders many things, [900]
and Fate brings all matters to a close. 1150

O my city, you tread the path of justice.
 Never abandon this course of action—
 honouring the gods. The man who asserts
 you are not just is veering close to madness,
 as these events establish. I tell you this,
 the testimony of gods is very clear—
 they always curb the pride of the unjust.

Your son, old lady, is now in heaven. [910]
 It is not right to claim that Herakles,
 his body eaten by searing flames, 1160
 descended to the home of Hades.¹¹
 No. He shares a bed with lovely Hebe
 in that golden palace on Olympus.
 O Hymen, you have honoured both,
 two children of great Zeus.¹²

Many things have come together here.
 Men say Athena assisted Herakles, [920]
 the father of these boys, and now Athens,
 that goddess's city, and its people
 have saved these children and checked the pride 1170
 of the man whose heart was filled with violence
 without a sense of justice. May my heart,
 my spirit, never crave such excess!

[Enter Servant and Soldiers with Eurystheus bound.]

SERVANT

My lady, although your eyes can see him,
 I will still report that we have come here
 bringing Eurystheus to you, a sight
 you did not expect, and no less for him [930]
 a stroke of evil luck he did not foresee
 when he and his hard-working infantry
 marched here from Mycenae, intending, 1180
 with high ambitions beyond all justice,
 to sack Athena's city. But a god
 changed his fortune and gave us a result
 that was the opposite of what he hoped.
 Hyllus and courageous Iolaus
 are putting up, as a memorial,
 a splendid statue of Zeus Triumphant,
 god of victory. But they ordered me
 to bring this man to you—they want to fill
 your heart with joy, for nothing is more sweet 1190

¹¹Herakles took some time to die from the effects of a poisoned tunic. In terrible pain, he arranged for a funeral pyre to be built and set alight with him lying on the fire.

¹²Hymen is the god of marriage. He is usually identified as a son of Apollo. Hebe is a daughter of Zeus and Hera.

than witnessing an enemy collapse
from great prosperity into disaster. [940]

ALCMEME [*to Eurystheus*]

You despicable man, you have marched here,
have you? Has Justice finally caught you?
You should begin by turning your head
to me and daring to look your enemies
in the face, for now you are no longer
the one who rules. No. Now you are a slave.
Are you the man—and this I wish to know—
who thought it right to inflict your malice 1200
so often on my son, wherever he is now?
You monster, you sent him off with orders
to slay hydras and lions, not to mention [950]
the other evils you prepared for him—
they would make my speech to you far too long.
What arrogant insults against Herakles
were beyond your daring? You even sent him
down to Hades while he was still alive.
But for you these harsh tasks were not enough.
Though we were suppliants to the gods 1210
and some of us were very old, while others
were still infants, you had to drive us out
of every city in Greece. But here you found
a city and citizens who were free
and did not fear you. And now you must go
to a miserable death that will be
in every way a benefit to you,
for you have caused us so much trouble,
you should not die just once, but many times. [960]

SERVANT

You will not be allowed to kill this man. 1220

ALCMENE

Then what is the point of making him
our prisoner? And what law prevents us
from putting him to death?

SERVANT

Those who rule this land
do not consider it appropriate.

ALCMENE

Why is that? Do people here in Athens
not think it splendid to kill their enemies?

SERVANT

No, not when they are captured in a fight
and are still alive.

HERAKLEIDAE

ALCMENE

What about Hyllus?
Did he approve of this position?

SERVANT

I suppose he should have disobeyed
his country's laws. 1230

ALCMENE

But Eurystheus
should not be alive, still gazing at the light.

SERVANT

He was not treated justly when he was captured—
that was the moment he should have been killed. [970]

ALCMENE

Surely it is still a glorious thing
for him to receive his punishment?

SERVANT

There is no one who may put him to death.

ALCMENE

I can. I claim to be somebody.

SERVANT

If you do, you will receive much blame.

ALCMENE

I love this city—no one can deny that.
But since this man has come into my hands,
there is no mortal being who will save him.
This being the case, anyone who wishes
may call me arrogant or too presumptuous
for a woman—nonetheless this killing
is something I will carry out. 1240 [980]

CHORUS

Lady,
your extreme hostility to this man
is something I can fully understand—
you can be forgiven for it.

EURYSTHEUS

Lady,
understand this clearly: I will not flatter you
or say anything else to save my life
that would make someone call me coward.
I did not choose this quarrel willingly. 1250

HERAKLEIDAE

I knew I was your cousin and kinsman
 of your son Herakles, but willing or not—
 for there was a god involved—Hera
 caused me to be stricken with this disease.¹³ [990]
 So once I vowed to be an enemy
 of Herakles and grasped that I would be
 playing my part in this hostility, 1260
 I became very skilled at stirring up
 all sorts of trouble. At night I stayed awake
 and constantly came up with many plans
 to keep at bay or kill my enemies,
 so I would not spend my future days in fear.
 I knew your son was no nonentity,
 but a real man, for although Herakles
 was my enemy, I will speak well of him, [1000]
 because he was so worthy. But now
 he is gone, his children all despise me, 1270
 and I am aware of their ancestral hate,
 so why should I leave any stone unturned
 devising ways to kill or banish them?
 By doing that I would remain secure.
 If you had been in my place, I suppose,
 and the lion had been your enemy,
 you would not have harassed its measly cubs
 but let them live on modestly in Argos.
 If you said that, no one would believe you.
 So now, since they did not kill me back then, 1280
 on the battlefield, when I wished to die, [1010]
 according to the customs of Greeks,
 the man who kills me carries out an act
 that is unholy. Your city spared my life,
 wisely deciding that honouring the gods
 was much more important than hating me.
 You have spoken and have heard my answer.
 From now on, you must call me by two names—
 an Avenging and a Noble Spirit.¹⁴
 Anyway, this how things stand with me— 1290
 I do not wish to die, but leaving life
 I would not find distressful.

CHORUS

Alcmene, I would like to give you
 a word of advice—let this man go free,
 since that is what the city thinks is right.

ALCMENE

What if he died, and I obeyed the city?

¹³Hera, divine wife of Zeus, was always hostile to Herakles, because he was the result of Zeus's adulterous sexual encounter with a mortal.

¹⁴There seems to be something missing in the Greek text here.

CHORUS

That would be better. How could it be done?

ALCMENE

I will explain—it is simple. I kill him
and then hand the corpse over to his friends
who come to get it. So with the body 1300
I will not be disobeying the city,
and by his death I will get justice.

EURYSTHEUS

Kill me. I am not asking to be spared.
But since this city let me go and refused
to slay me, I will offer it a gift—
an ancient oracle of Loxias,
which in time will bring greater benefits
than you might imagine.¹⁵ When I am dead,
you must bury me in my destined place—
in front of the shrine of the virgin goddess 1300
who dwells in Pallene.¹⁶ And I shall lie
forever beneath your land, a foreigner
who is kind to you and guards the city,
but a bitter enemy to the descendants
of Herakles's children when they come here
with a huge force, betraying your kindness.
That is what they are like, these suppliants
you are protecting. You may well ask me
why I came here instead of honouring
the oracle of the god. I came because 1310
I thought that Hera was far more powerful
and would not fail me. But do not let [1040]
libations or the victims' blood drip down
into my grave. If you do this, in return
I will give them a disastrous journey home.
You will get a double benefit from me—
by my death I will be helping Athens
and harming descendants of Herakles.

ALCMENE [*to the soldiers guarding Eurystheus*]

You heard what he said. Why hesitate
to kill this man if, by doing that, 1320
you can make Athens and your children safe?
He is showing us the safest path.
The man is our enemy, but his death
bring us benefits. You slaves, take him away [1050]
to the place where you will kill him
and then throw his body to the dogs.

¹⁵Loxias is another name for the god Apollo.

¹⁶This is a reference to the goddess Athena. Pallene was a district within the city of Athens.

HERAKLEIDAE

[Alcmene turns to Eurystheus.]

You can give up any hopes you have
that you will live to banish me again
from my native land.

CHORUS

That seems best to me, as well.
Move on, you servants. What we are doing
will keep our rulers free from any guilt.

1330

[Exeunt Eurystheus, Attendants, Guards, and Chorus.]